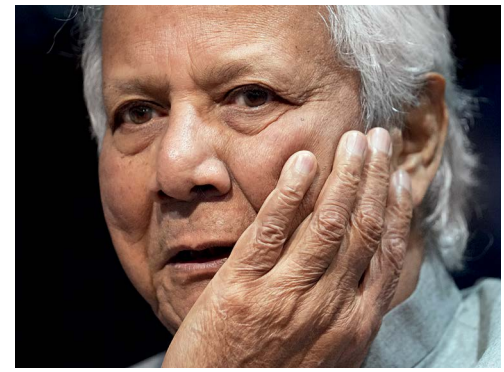


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AP

AMONG THE FIRST THINGS YUNUS DID WAS LIFT THE JAMAAT BAN. ANTI-INDIA FORCES HAVE GAINED GROUND SINCE. STUDENT LEADERS ARE SUSPECTED TO HAVE LINKS WITH RADICALS

CIVIL COUNT

2,010
Total incidents

9
Murders

69
Attacks on places of worship

4
Atrocities against women

Source: Hindu Buddhist Christian Unity Council

GOVERNMENT ESTIMATES

88
Registered no. of cases of communal violence targeting minorities

70
No. of people arrested; other allegations being investigated

Source: Press secretary, Interim Government

Earlier, incidents of intimidation and violence against minorities in Bangladesh were triggered by the stunning ouster of Bangladeshi prime minister Sheikh Hasina in a student uprising on August 5. In the chaotic aftermath of that event, hundreds of attacks were reported against Hindu individuals and properties. According to the Hindu Buddhist Christian Unity Council (HBCUC), a key advocacy group for minority rights, 2,010 such incidents took place between August 4 and 20, including nine murders, 69 attacks on places of worship and four incidents of violence against women. Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who was the first global leader to recognise the new dispensation when he tweeted his support for Yunus on X, had also asked him to ensure the "safety and protection of Hindus and all other minority communities". Even US president-elect Donald Trump had tweeted on X after Christian schools were attacked in Dhaka: "I strongly condemn the barbaric violence against Hindus, Christians and other minorities who are getting attacked and looted by mobs in Bangladesh, which remains in a total state of chaos."

However, the Yunus government claims that the HBCUC numbers on the incidents of communal violence are vastly exaggerated, even as it acknowledged some of the incidents listed. On December 10, the government reported that between August 4 and August 20, 88 cases had been registered, and 70 arrests made for vandalism of Hindu temples and other acts of violence against minorities. The interim government has also often argued that violence against minorities in Bangladesh stems more from political vengeance than communal hatred. The Hindu community had largely supported Hasina's Awami League and is seen as an easy target for retribution. "It is true that most Hindus supported Hasina," says Regan Acharjee, a 36-year-old lawyer in Chittagong. "But is it our fault that other political parties couldn't earn our trust? Does that make us soft targets?" Acharjee's rhetorical questions capture the frustration and despair of a community that feels victimised for its political allegiances.

Hidden in plain sight, the Sevak community, or the Hindi-speaking Hindus scattered across Bangladesh, stands as a relic of colonial history. Brought to the region by British rulers to serve as menial workers, their ancestors were from North India. Over the decades, these communities have remained in the country, eking out a modest existence while largely aligning politically with the Awami League, who they regarded as the most secular party. At 13.1 million, Hindus